



Midnight
Run Cafe

Midnight Run Cafe - Website Redesign

Improving the Midnight Run Cafe website
through user-centered design.



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Project Introduction



Local cafe in Waterloo



Serves as a study/work space and social hub



Offers foods, drinks and community events



Website needs to add menus, hours and events



Project Goals



Understand Users

How users interact
with the current
website



Identify Needs

User needs,
expectations,
and pain points



Improve Experience

Improve usability
and overall
user experience



Problem

The Midnight Run Cafe website lacks clear structure and organization, making it difficult for users to find important information such as menus, hours, and events. This leads to confusion, reduced engagement, and an overall less effective user experience.



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Research Plan



User Interviews



- Conduct one-on-one interviews to gather in-depth user insights
- Understand user behaviors, needs, and pain points

User Surveys



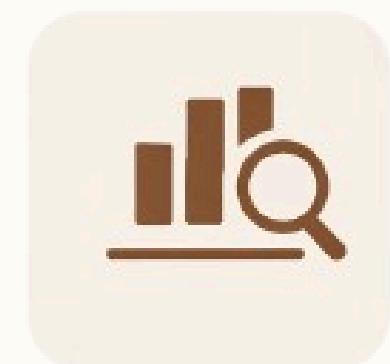
- Distribute surveys to collect quantitative feedback
- Identify trends and common user expectations

Usability Testing



- Observe users interacting with the current website
- Identify usability issues and navigation challenges

Heuristic Evaluation



- Analyze strengths and weaknesses of similar cafe websites
- Identify opportunities for improvement and differentiation



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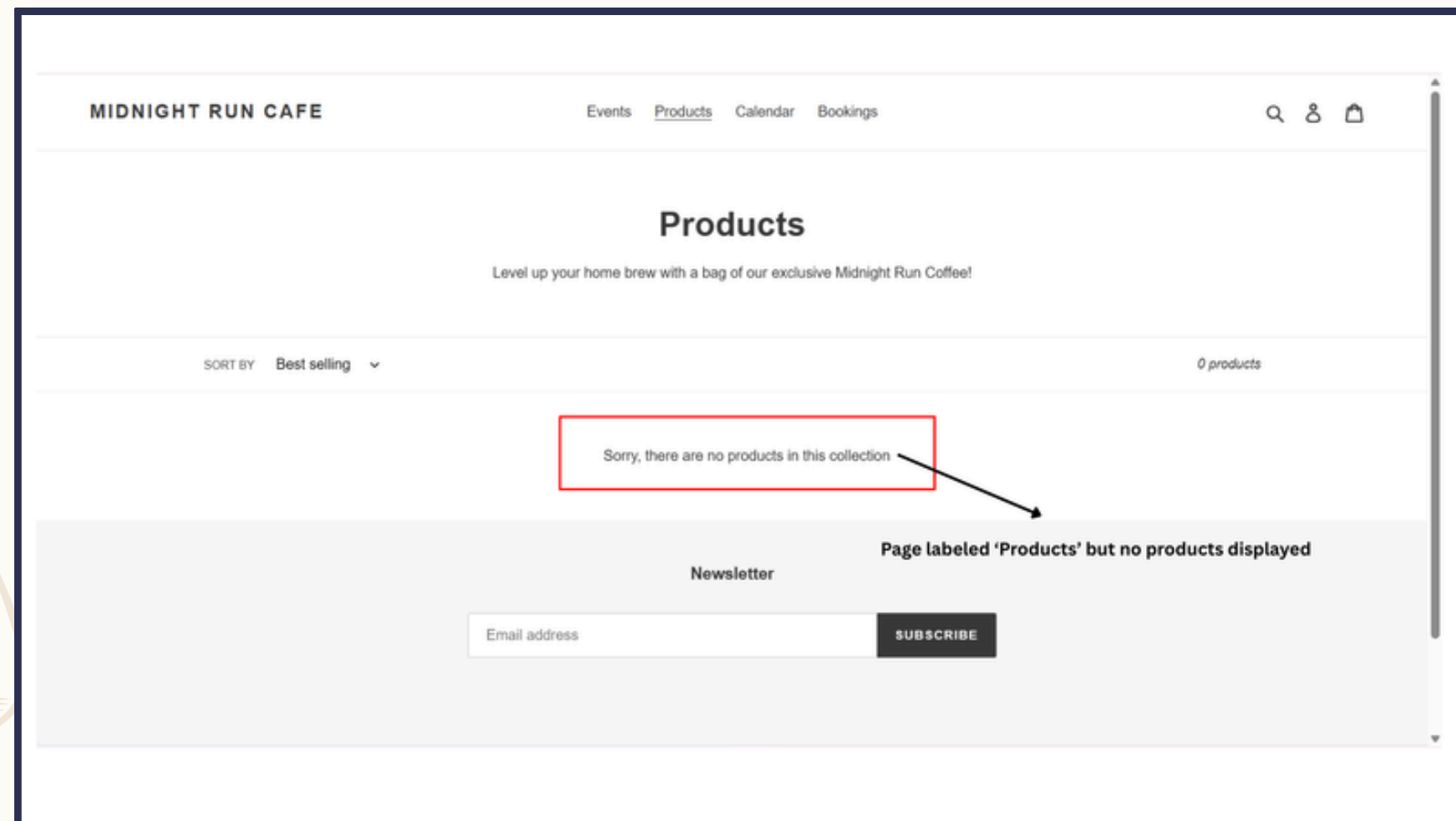


Heuristic Evaluation Overview

Evaluated using Nielsen's 10 heuristics
Goal: identify usability + accessibility issues



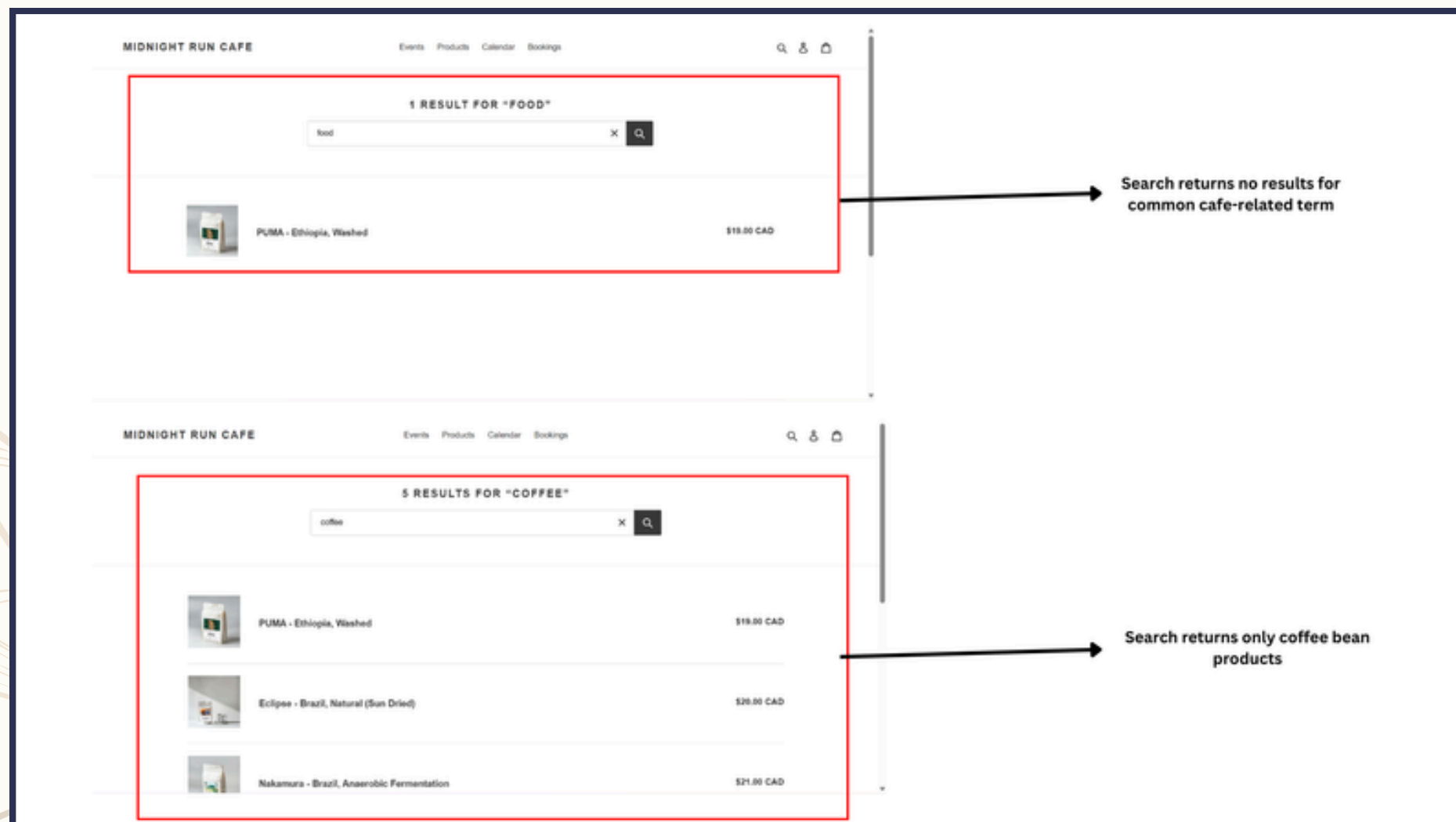
Poor System Status Visibility



No feedback is provided when content is missing, leaving users unsure what is happening



Mismatch with Real-World Expectations

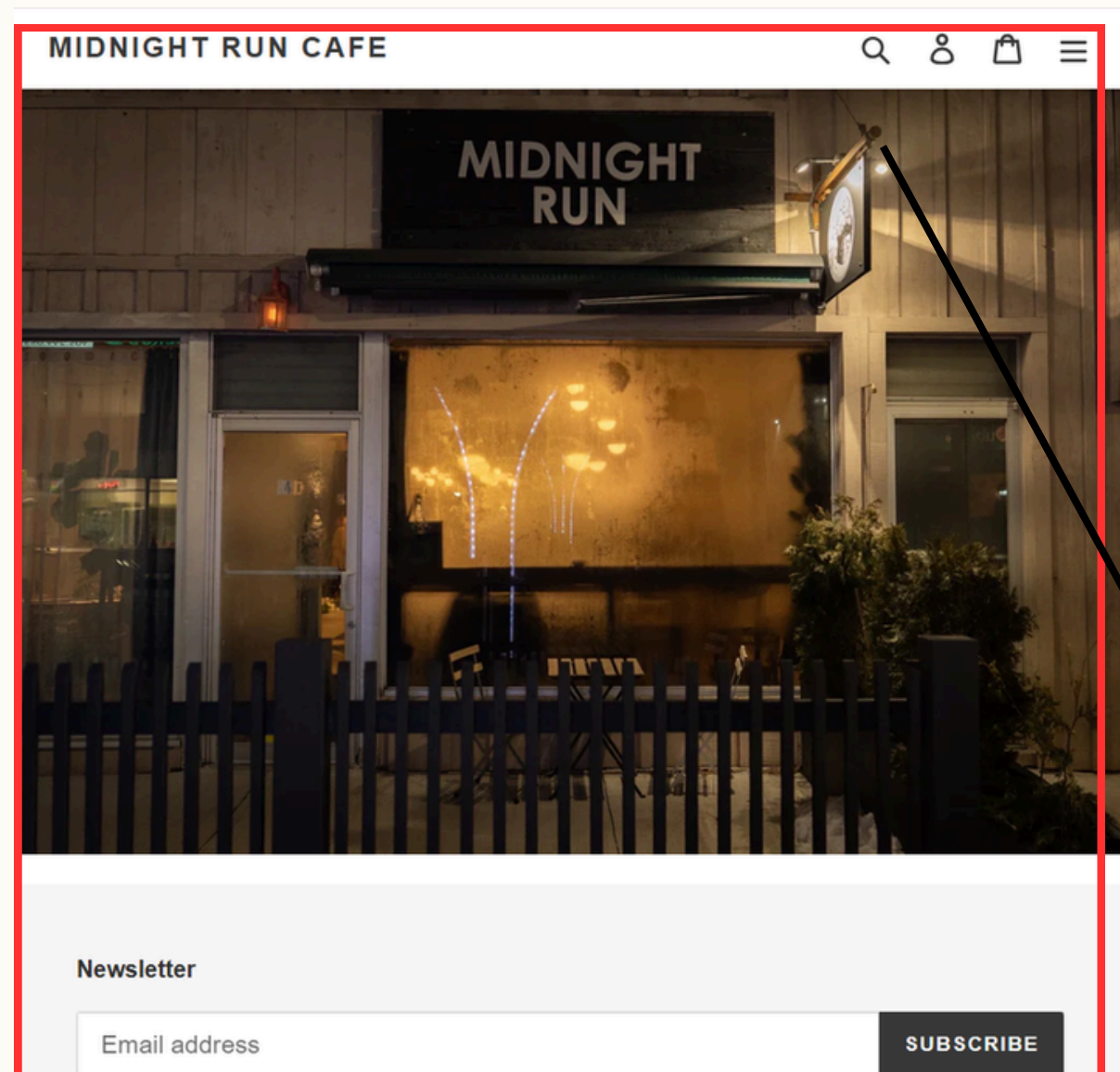


Search results don't match user expectations

Users expect drinks + menu items, not limited or missing results



Lack of Content & Clarity



Clean design, but missing key information. Users lack enough detail to make decisions

The homepage relies primarily on a single image and does not display essential information such as products, new location details, or hours of operation, limiting users' ability to quickly understand what the café offers.



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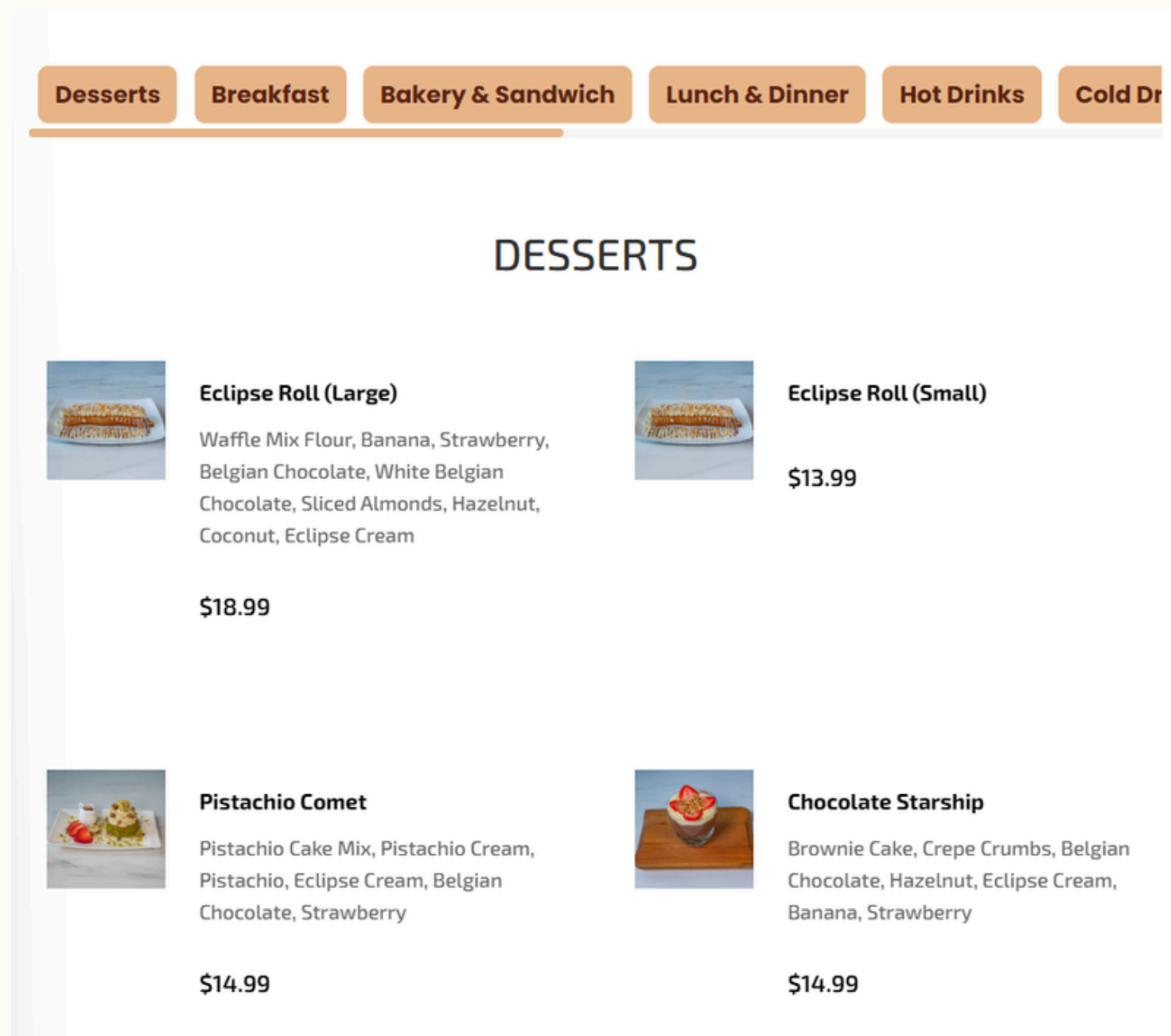
Competitive Analysis

Abe Erb + Eclipse Cafe





Clear Menu Structure



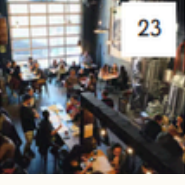
Structured, categorized menu

Items are grouped logically with clear label. Users can quickly understand available options



Events Visibility



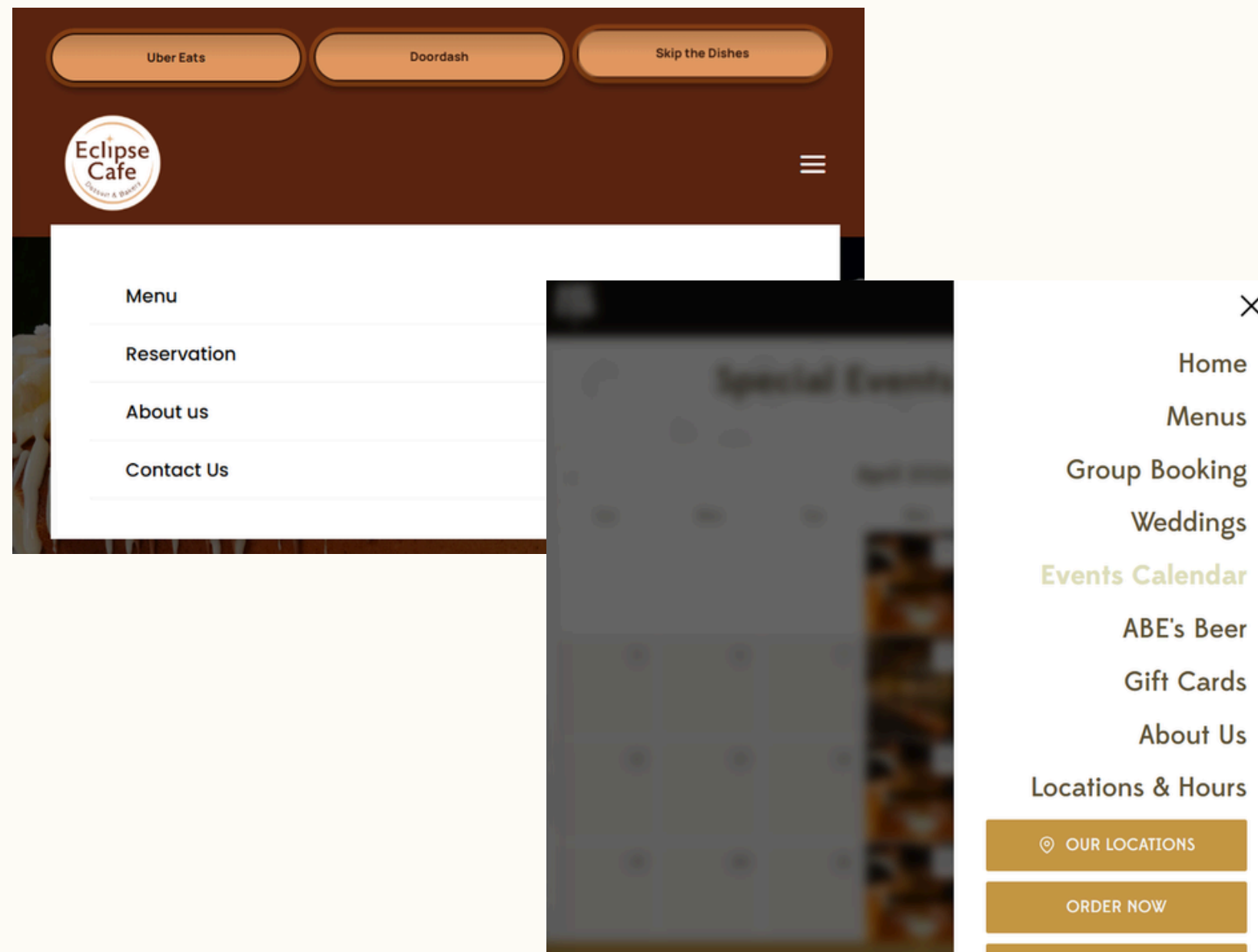
April 2026						
Sun	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat
		WATERLOO TRIVIA 08:00pm - 10:00pm 15 King St. S. Waterloo ABE ERB				
5	6				10	
12	13	14			17	18
19	20	21			24	25

Events are clearly presented and discoverable

Dedicated sections highlight activities and offerings. Users can understand what's happening before visiting



Clear & Intuitive Navigation



Clear navigation supports efficient task completion

Key pages are clearly labeled and consistently placed. Users can find information without excessive searching



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Interviews

Key Insights

- Cafes are more than just a place to get coffee
- Physical environment is key
- Digital presence is important but lacking here





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Persona



Emily Chen

Age: 19



Program: Arts



Location: Waterloo



Marital: Single



Occupation: Student + part-time job



Income: \$12k-\$18k

Emily is a first-year university student who frequently searches online for comfortable study environments near campus. When she hears about a café from friends or social media, she usually visits the café's website before deciding whether to go. On the Midnight Run Café website, Emily wants to quickly understand the atmosphere of the space and whether it would be a good place to study for several hours. She browses photos of the café, checks the menu to see if drinks and snacks are affordable, and confirms the café's hours. If the website clearly communicates the café's environment and offerings, she is more likely to visit.

Website navigation

Mobile browsing

Online research

Digital payments

Needs and Goals

- Quickly understand the vibe and atmosphere of the café
- View photos of the space to see if it looks quiet and comfortable
- Check the menu and pricing for drinks/snacks
- Confirm opening hours
- Find the location and distance from campus

Painpoints

- Websites that lack photos of the interior space
- Difficulty finding menus or prices
- Unclear opening hours or location details
- Slow-loading pages on mobile devices
- Too much text instead of quick visuals

Motivations

- Finding a comfortable place outside of her dorm
- Discovering new cafés around campus
- Choosing places that feel aesthetically pleasing
- Ensuring the café offers affordable drinks





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Empathy Map

Empathy Map Emily Chen



Says

- I'm looking for a quiet, cozy café near campus where I can study.
- 'What does this café look like inside?
- Do they serve affordable coffee and snacks?
- I need a café that's open late for studying.

Thinks

- 💡 I hope this café has good Wi-Fi and enough outlets.
- ♥ Is this a good place to study for a few hours?
- ♥ I wish there was a café closer to campus.
- ♥ Will it be too crowded or noisy?



Does

- Searches for cafés online or on Google Maps.
- Looks at photos to see if the space looks comfortable.
- Reads reviews about atmosphere and seating.
- Compares drink prices and menu options.

Feels

- ♥ Happy when she finds a cozy café with a good vibe.
- ♥ Frustrated when websites hide important info.
- ♥ Overwhelmed when sites are cluttered.
- ♥ Relaxed when photos and details are easy to find.

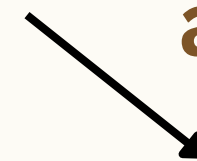




User Journey Maps

What is each step of the user journey?	Discover	Understand	Engage	Act	Remember
User actions What action does the user take during each step?	Searches Google for cafes with Wi-Fi or workspace environments	Opens cafe website to check hours, menu, Wi-Fi, seating, and environment	Uses the website to confirm location and decides to visit	Uses the website again while at the cafe to check menu, events, or hours	Returns to the website later to plan future visits
Goals & experiences What is the user trying to accomplish?	Discover cafes nearby that could work as productive workspaces	Quickly understand if the cafe supports working (Wi-Fi, outlets, quiet environment)	Confirm essential information before leaving home	Easily access information while at the cafe	Remember the cafe as a reliable workspace option
Feelings and thoughts Use the emojis below to help illustrate how the user might be feeling.	"I need a cafe where I can work for a few hours." 🤔	"Does this cafe actually have Wi-Fi and enough seating?" 🤔	"Okay, this looks like a good place to try." 😊	"Let me quickly check the menu or hours." 🤔	"This place works well — I'll come back again." 😊
Pain points What's not working well? What causes friction? How many people does this affect? (On a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 is 'a few people' and 5 is 'many people') How bad is the pain?	Cafe search results don't clearly show work-friendly features	Website lacks clear information about Wi-Fi, outlets, or seating	Important details like hours or menu are hard to find	Navigation is unclear or key information requires scrolling	No reminders or incentives encouraging return visits
Opportunities How might we address these pain points? How big is the opportunity if we correct this pain point? What are new ways to serve this person?	Improve SEO and clearly communicate workspace-friendly features online	Add clear sections for Wi-Fi, seating, outlets, and study/work suitability	Design homepage with quick access to hours, menu, and location	Simplify navigation and highlight frequently accessed info	Promote loyalty programs, events, or workspace amenities to returning users

Users cannot determine if the cafe meets their core needs like workspace suitability due to missing and unclear details



Throughout the stage there are unclear navigation left users feeling extremely frustrated and hesitant to be able to make a clear decision.

JORDAN MORALES
Marketing Specialist



Usability Testing



TASK SUCCESS BREAKDOWN METRICS

TASK	Percentage	INTERPRETION
UNDERSTANDING CAFE OFFERING	0%	Users could not identify the purpose of the website
FINDING THE MENU	0%	Menu structure does not align with user expectations
FIND OPENING HOURS	0%	Critical information is misssing or not visible
FIND EVENTS	100%	Events are actually acessible
STUDY SUITABILITY	0%	The website doesn't give any information concerning this
SEARCH OF ITEM	0%	Search results do not match user intent
NAVIGATING PAGE	75%	Users naviagted the website but it was quite diifficult





Usability Testing



ERROR RATE

TASK	TOTAL ERRORS	AVG ERRORS PER PARTICIPANT	ERROR SEVERITY
UNDERSTANDING CAFE OFFERING	4	1.0	High
FINDING THE MENU	8	2.0	High
FIND OPENING HOURS	9	2.25	High
FIND EVENTS	4	1.0	Medium
STUDY SUITABILITY	4	1.0	High
SEARCH OF ITEM	10	2.5	Very High
NAVIGATING PAGE	7	1.75	Medium – High





Usability Testing



VERBAL FRUSTRATION

Scale Definition

- **1 = No frustration** (smooth experience)
- **2 = Low frustration** (minor hesitation)
- **3 = Moderate frustration** (clear confusion)
- **4 = High frustration** (repeated issues, negative comments)
- **5 = Very high frustration** (strong negative reactions, task breakdown)

TASK	AVG FRUSTRATION SCORE	FRUSTRATION LEVEL
UNDERSTANDING CAFE OFFERING	4.0	High
FINDING THE MENU	5.0	Very High
FIND OPENING HOURS	4.5	Very High
FIND EVENTS	3.0	Moderate
STUDY SUITABILITY	4.0	High
SEARCH OF ITEM	5.0	Very High
NAVIGATING PAGE	3.5	Moderate– High





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Key Insights



- Critical Information is missing during decision-making
- Navigation does not align with user expectations.
- Lack of Clarity leads to frustration and indecision



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Design Recommendations



Based on our research, we recommend the following improvements to enhance usability and clarity



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Improve Content Clarity

- Rename “Products” → “Menu”: This aligns with user expectations
- Add clear menu, hours, and cafe offerings: This ensures users understand what the cafe offers
- Include events + study/work information





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Improve Navigation & Structure

- Simplify navigation with clear labels
- Reduce reliance on scrolling: Above the fold mentality
- Improve page hierarchy and organization





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Improve Feedback & User Confidence

- Add empty states like “Coming soon” to prevent confusion on blank pages
- Provide feedback for actions like confirmation, search results, navigation
- Improve perceived completeness to build trust and credibility





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Thank you!

Improving the Midnight Run Cafe website
through user-centered design.

